

Template Reviews & Benefits

1. Experiential Team-Building Task Sheets

(Sources: *Paper Tower Task Sheet*, *Spaghetti Tower Task Sheet*)

- **Benefits:** These templates provide ready-to-use, highly constrained exercises designed to test a team's ability to plan and execute under pressure. Both exercises force teams to manage limited resources (e.g., paper batches, or strictly 20 spaghetti sticks and a marshmallow) within a rigid 30-minute window (20 minutes of preparation and 10 minutes of construction) without the ability to prefabricate.
- **How it helps the Advisor (Facilitator):** It creates a high-pressure microcosm of the workplace, allowing the advisor to step back and observe natural team dynamics, communication breakdowns, and leadership styles in real-time. It perfectly sets the stage for a targeted, observational debrief.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** It safely exposes underlying operational flaws within their team—such as jumping to solutions without a plan or allowing dominant personalities to override the process—without the real-world financial risks.
- **Suitable for:** Business owners, departmental managers, and corporate teams participating in off-site retreats, strategic planning days, or leadership training.

2. Analytical & Scoring Tools

(Source: *Paper Tower Model*)

- **Benefits:** This spreadsheet translates a simple team-building game into a tangible financial exercise. It calculates the fictional "Profit or Loss" of the tower based on material costs (\$2,000 per batch of 20 sheets), time taken, and height achieved (with a \$10,000 bonus for exceeding 2400mm).
- **How it helps the Advisor:** It shifts the focus of the exercise from merely "building the tallest tower" to executing a profitable business strategy. It gives the advisor quantitative data to challenge the team during the debrief.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** It teaches the team the importance of running a financial calculation *prior* to beginning construction, reinforcing that revenue (height) must be balanced against operational expenses (paper costs) and labor (time) to achieve true profitability.
- **Suitable for:** Executive teams, project managers, and finance departments who need to focus on resource allocation and profitability over sheer output.

3. Debrief & Process Frameworks

(Sources: *Paper Tower Review Questions*, *Team Problem Solving Slides*)

- **Benefits:** These templates bridge the gap between playing a game and implementing real workplace change. They provide a structured 9-step "Core Problem Solving Process" to navigate the transition from problem identification to execution.

- **How it helps the Advisor:** It scripts the debriefing process. Instead of asking generic questions, the advisor is guided to read back exact, time-stamped observations (e.g., "At 2:42 into the exercise, Jim said..."). The slide deck provides a professional, research-backed framework (referencing HBR and McKinsey) to establish the advisor's authority.
- **How it helps the Business Owner:** The team learns to replace chaotic problem-solving with a disciplined framework. They learn vital skills such as setting S.M.A.R.T. objectives, brainstorming without premature assessment (fostering psychological safety), and appointing an "Enforcer" to take operational ownership of the outcome.
- **Suitable for:** Any team that suffers from analysis paralysis, lacks structured meeting agendas, or struggles to bring ideas to execution.

How to Use the Material in Practice: Step-by-Step Methods

Step 1: Select and Introduce the Exercise Choose either the Paper Tower or Spaghetti Tower exercise based on your goals. Distribute the respective Task Sheet and read the constraints out loud. Emphasize that they have exactly 20 minutes to prepare and 10 minutes to build, and that prefabrication is strictly forbidden.

Step 2: Observe and Document As the 30-minute timer runs, do not intervene. Act as a silent observer. Document specific quotes, behaviors, and the exact timestamps of when critical decisions were made or when the process broke down. If running the Paper Tower, act as the supplier, handing out paper in batches of 20 and recording their usage.

Step 3: Measure and Calculate Results Once the build time expires, measure the tower from the surface. Ensure it remains self-supporting for at least one minute. If using the Paper Tower, input their material costs, time, and height into the **Paper Tower Model** spreadsheet to calculate their final profit or loss.

Step 4: Conduct the Observational Debrief Use the **Paper Tower Review Questions**. Begin by asking if they had fun, then immediately transition into reading back your time-stamped observations. Ask critical questions: "Did anybody complete a financial calculation prior to developing the construction plan?" and "Were you outcome-oriented or process-driven?".

Step 5: Teach the 9-Step Framework Transition to the **Team Problem Solving** slides. Explain that teams fail because they jump straight to solutions without a shared understanding of the problem. Walk them through the 9 steps, starting with appointing a Chairperson and Timekeeper.

Step 6: Workplace Application Maximize the ROI of the exercise by brainstorming back-at-work applications for this new 9-step process. Conclude by having the team identify an "Enforcer"—an individual who will take psychological and operational ownership to ensure the momentum doesn't dissipate.

Common Q&A

Q1: Why do teams typically fail these experiential exercises?

A: Research and observation suggest teams usually fail because they jump straight to solutions without a shared understanding of the problem. They frequently fail to accurately define a S.M.A.R.T. objective and fail to brainstorm effectively, often running with the first idea without assessing alternatives.

Q2: What is the most critical rule during the "Brainstorming" phase of problem-solving?

A: There must be strictly no assessment of ideas during the generation phase. Premature assessment is a frequent point of failure; facilitators must enforce psychological safety by congratulating all contributions to foster divergent thinking and lower social barriers to creativity.

Q3: How is "Profit" determined in the Paper Tower exercise?

A: Profitability is calculated using three metrics: the quantity of materials drawn (\$2,000 per batch of 20 sheets), the time taken in minutes, and the height of the tower, with a \$10,000 bonus awarded for heights exceeding 2400mm.

Q4: How should a team filter down their ideas after brainstorming?

A: Once divergent thinking is complete, teams must move to convergent thinking (Step 7: Eliminate and Select Best Option). A highly useful tool for this stage is the "Impact vs. Effort Matrix" to narrow the focus to high-impact solutions.

Q5: What makes an objective truly effective for a team?

A: A written objective must be S.M.A.R.T. (Specific, Measurable, Agreed, Revisable, and Time-bound). Furthermore, it must not only state the action being taken but clearly articulate *why* achieving it is critical.

Q6: What is the role of the "Enforcer" in the final step?

A: A solution without a budget or a dedicated team is merely a wish. The Enforcer takes psychological and operational ownership of the Action Plan (Step 9). They monitor milestones, report back on progress, and ensure the momentum generated during the planning phase actually results in tangible output.

Sources Provided

Template Name	Core Focus & Contents
Paper Tower Model	A financial spreadsheet used to calculate the fictional profit or loss of a paper tower based on materials used, time taken, and height achieved.
Paper Tower Review Questions	A facilitator's debrief document containing observational questions and introducing the 9-step team problem-solving model to apply back at the workplace.
Paper Tower Task Sheet	Participant instructions for a 30-minute team exercise to build a paper tower, detailing resource limits, constraints, and profitability metrics.
Spaghetti Tower Task Sheet	Participant instructions for building the tallest self-supporting tower using strictly 20 pieces of spaghetti, tape, string, and marshmallows within 30 minutes.
Team Problem Solving	A facilitator's slide deck outlining the 9-step organizational problem-solving framework, focusing on SMART objectives, brainstorming rules, and assigning an Enforcer.

AI Logic Branch Table: Team Facilitation & Problem Solving

Logic Branch	IF (Condition / Trigger)	THEN (Action / Next Step)	Additional Context / Notes
Exercise Selection	IF the client wants to test resource management and financial planning under pressure...	THEN select and distribute the "Paper Tower Task Sheet" and utilize the "Paper Tower Model".	This exercise forces the team to balance the cost of materials (\$2k per batch) against the potential revenue (height) to achieve profitability.
Exercise Selection (Alt)	IF the client wants a pure creativity and structural problem-solving challenge...	THEN select and distribute the "Spaghetti Tower Task Sheet".	Focuses purely on height and structural integrity using highly brittle materials (spaghetti) and a top-heavy constraint (marshmallow).
Debrief Initiation	IF the 30-minute exercise concludes and the towers are measured...	THEN transition to the "Paper Tower Review Questions" and read back time-stamped observations.	State exactly what you saw and heard (e.g., "At 2:42 into the exercise, Jim said..."). Ask if they were outcome-oriented or process-driven.
Process Correction	IF the team failed the exercise because they immediately started building without a plan...	THEN present Step 3 of the Team Problem Solving deck: "Determine the Objective".	Explain that a common point of failure is lacking a S.M.A.R.T. objective that states not only <i>what</i> is being done, but <i>why</i> it is important.

Brainstorming Rule	IF team members are arguing or shooting down each other's ideas during planning...	THEN enforce Step 5: "Brainstorm Without Assessment".	Remind the team that judgment must be deferred entirely. Congratulate all contributions to maintain psychological safety and foster divergent thinking.
Execution Accountability	IF the team has selected a great idea but has a history of failing to implement...	THEN enforce Step 8 and 9 by allocating resources and appointing an "Enforcer".	The Enforcer must take operational ownership of the Action Plan, monitor milestones, and report back on barriers to ensure the ROI of the session is realized.
